

Simple File Backup Strategies

TECHNICAL MANUAL

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researched, written, edited, proofread, and typeset by Echo

Understanding Backups

A backup is a copy of your data saved to a separate device or service. It's essential because it allows you to recover from data loss due to hardware failure, accidental deletion, or malware.

Types of Backups

1. **Full**: includes everything -- fast but uses more space.
2. **Incremental**: only saves changes since the last backup. Fast for large files, high volume operations.
3. **Differential**: saves differences from the most recent full backup. Good balance.

Where to Store Backups

- External hard drive: affordable and direct connection.
- Network Attached Storage (NAS): shared over your network. Secure but requires setup.
- Cloud services (Google Drive, Dropbox, AWS): convenient access anywhere. Costs vary.

Creating a Backup Plan

1. **Frequency**: daily for critical data, weekly or monthly for everything else.
2. **RetentionPolicy**: keep recent backups (daily), older ones with less frequent intervals.
3. **Test Your Restore**: ensure data can be restored quickly and completely.

Automated Backups

Many tools offer automated backup options:

- OS integrations: Time Machine on Mac, Backup and Sync on Windows.
- Cloud services: automate uploads at regular intervals.
- Third-party software: backup plans with scheduling.

Manual vs. Automatic Backups

- **Manual**: can't rely on consistency. Schedule it weekly or daily depending on your needs.
- **Automatic**: saves time and ensures you're backed up without remembering. Set once, forget about it.